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Visitor Attractions: The Future of Social Media in Heritage, Urban and Natural Tourism

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Abstract

Social media is the number one activity on the internet that is used by one and a half billion users every year. These online platforms are greatly benefiting the tourism industry as it offers many different marketing opportunities, targeting channels and significantly influences the tourist's decisions. The Irish tourism industry are commencing their social media strategies beginning from the Destination Marketing Organisation and National Tourism Development Authority, however some industry operators such as visitor attractions, are not yet fully utilising the obtainable marketing opportunities. This research is focusing on three visitor attractions in three particular sectors of the tourism industry, heritage, urban and natural. The aim of the research is to determine what efforts are currently in place with their existing social media campaigns and what can be done to improve the return on investment. Perhaps the identification of a future social media strategy for Irish visitor attractions can result in the successful re-development of a company's overall marketing strategy. Further to this identification, the main objective of selecting visitor attractions from three sectors of the tourism industry is to determine if social media content should be focused on sectors of the tourism industry. The research was obtained through a mixed methodology containing primary and secondary research, using qualitative and quantitative results. The first stage was to carry out a literature review to identify gaps in the research. Books, articles, E-journals, websites and Fáilte Ireland reports were examined to initially distinguish existing literature views regarding the best approach tourism industry operators should take in relation to their social media campaigns. Following the findings of the literature review, the researcher examined the information and the gaps further by conducting three interviews with visitor attraction operators and carrying out sixty questionnaires with previous tourists of the three attractions under review. Each objective of the research study was answered and recommendations were established for the future of visitor attractions social networking campaigns. It is now evident that the future of marketing for tourism organisations will be through social networking mediums, therefore not adapting or embracing this marketing tool will subsequently effect the marketing achievements of the company.

Keywords: Heritage Attraction; Social Media; Urban Attraction; Natural Attraction; Ireland

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1. Introduction

Use of social media is the number one activity on the internet and it is quickly emerging as one of the top marketing tools used by over 93% of marketers for business. Tourists are increasingly searching through online blogs, review sites and other social media sources for the purpose of gathering information to assist in planning their itinerary. The majority of content on each social media site is consumer generated therefore companies have limited control over the information and posts relating to their business. The tourism industry is widely embracing social media specifically through review websites and blogs however many industry operators are not fully utilising what limited control they do have in managing content relating to their

organisation. Subsequently tourism businesses are not exploiting the marketing opportunities social media offers. Visitor attractions in Ireland have been selected as the subject matter under investigation due to their target market for example, domestic families and international tourists, as these market segments use the internet to conduct their travel planning. Visitor attractions from the heritage sector, urban sector and natural sector of the tourism industries have been chosen as the field of study. The attractions are to be examined as follows;

1. Bunratty Castle and Fold Park - Co. Clare, Ireland (Heritage Attraction)
2. Guinness Storehouse – Co. Dublin, Ireland (Urban Attraction)

3. Cliffs of Moher - Co. Clare, Ireland (Natural Attraction)

The purpose of looking at three different sectors of the tourism industry is to distinguish whether there is a specific approach tourism operators should take in relation to their sector of the tourism industry. The researcher will diagnose whether the types of attractions, being heritage, urban and natural are using the most applicable approach to social media and what areas they have yet to infiltrate. In doing this, the researcher will be able to estimate the future social media life span for each attraction and recommend what is the best way to utilise social media marketing opportunities.

The main aim of this research is to understand how visitor attractions should be represented through social media. The objectives of the research were developed following a review of a select number of visitor attractions' social media pages, distinguishing the topic of social networking and a review of the current literature covered to date. In order to achieve the main aim of the study, the five following objectives are set: to identify why it is important for visitor attractions to use social media as a marketing tool; to monitor the change in the online marketing environment and the different requirements of tourism operators; to analyse challenges industry operators face from the use of social networking; to differentiate between re-active (creating social media profiles just to show presence) or pro-active (keeping profile pages active) use of social networking; and to identify what the future of social media will be for the named attractions.

2. Literature review

2.1.1. Definition of Social media and Web 2.0

Social media has been defined by many academics over the past number of years, many of which relate to the research carried out by the authors. Blackshaw and Nazzaro (2004) defined social media as “a new and emerging source of online information that are created, initiated, circulated and used by consumers with the intent of educating each other about products, brands, services and issues” (Blackshaw & Nazzaro, 2004, p. 5). This definition was created during the same year as the birth of Facebook; however, the topic was then refined as: “An internet-based application that carry consumer-generated content which encompasses media impressions created by consumers typically informed by relevant experience and archived or shared online for easy access by other impressionable consumers” (Blackshaw & Nazzaro, 2006 cited by Xiang and Gretzel, 2010). Similarly, Kaplan & Haelain (2010) defined social networking as “Internet-based applications that build on the ideological and technological foundations of Web 2.0 and that allow the creation and exchange of User-Generated Content” (Kaplan and Haelain, 2010, p. 61).

Web 2.0 can often be misinterpreted as social media; however, both social media and Web 2.0 are married as an

online social domain. Web 2.0 is “the way people use the web to easily publish information online, share that information with others, and develop relationships and communicate interactively with people who share common interests” (McDonald, 2010). Both online social domains work in diverse fashions however complement each other for similar communication benefits, “Web 2.0 is the platform for the evolution of social media” (Kaplan and Haelain, 2010, p. 61). Fig 2.1 shows the evolution of the ‘intraweb’ and distinguishes the difference between Web 2.0 and Web 3.0. Social networking was established during the Web 2.0 growth. The link between social media and Web 2.0 is, they are both user-generated content (UGC), which can be seen as “the sum of all ways in which people make use of social media” (Kaplan and Haelain, 2010, p. 61).

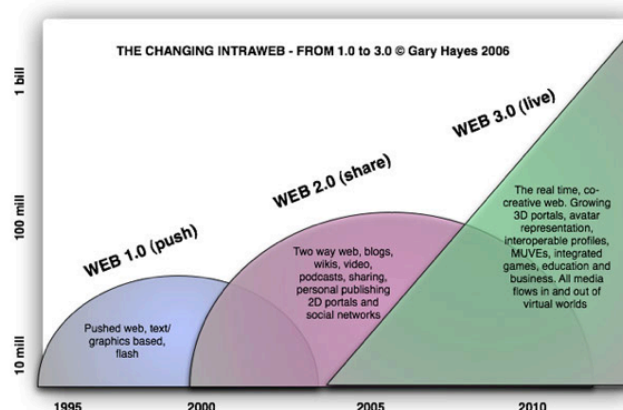


Figure 1: Evolution of Web 2.0.

2.1.2. Relationship definition between social media and Web 2.0

O'Reilly (2007) defined the relationship as Web 2.0 being the network and social media as an application of that network and the definition has been widely cited over numerous academic research. “Web 2.0 is the network as a platform, spanning all connected devices; Web 2.0 applications are those that make the most of the intrinsic advantages of that platform” (O'Reilly, 2007, p. 2). Social media, along with blogs, wikis (webpages that any person can access or modify), photo and video sharing, “all fall under the Web 2.0 moniker” (Gallaughier, 2009, p. 1). “Web 2.0 transforms travellers from passive consumers to active prosumers (producers and consumers)” (Sigala et al. 2010, p. 7). These active consumers take part in ‘peer production’. Peer production is when users collaboratively work to create content and provide services online i.e. UGC. Public boards are an example of mass collaboration created entirely from any member of the public.

2.2. Visitor Attractions

A business is considered to be a tourism attraction if “it is in a permanently established excursion destination that charges admission for ... sightseeing or allowed access for

entertainment, interest or education... it has to be open to the public and attract mostly tourists" (Weidenfield et al, 2010, p.15). Similarly, Leask (2010) defines tourist attractions as "A permanent resource, either natural or human-made, which is developed and managed for the primary purpose of attracting visitors" (Hu & Wall as cited in Leask, 2010, p. 1). Although not all visitor attractions charge an entrance fee, a number of definitions class attractions as fee paying. For example, "An attraction is where it is feasible to charge admission for the sole purpose of sightseeing" (Discovernorthernireland.com). "The significance of the visitor attraction sector is increasingly being recognised in regards to the role attractions play in identifying the success of a tourism destination ... by providing facilities and recreation for the tourist and developing a greater feel of civic pride and local identity" (Garrod et al, 2012, p. 1). Each visitor attraction is based on a specific sector of the tourism industry for example museums are related to culture tourism, castles are heritage tourism and landscapes are generally natural tourism. As the heritage, urban and natural sectors of the tourism industry are the areas of focus, the researcher will review the literature published for each sector.

2.2.1. Heritage Attractions

Heritage has been described as an essential element of national representation (Park, 2010) "Heritage tourism is inextricably bound up with experiencing both material (tangible) and socio-psychological (intangible) remnants of the nation's past" (Park, 2010, pp. 1-2). Visitor attractions produced from the heritage sector of the tourism industry can have both tangible and intangible elements of representation however ultimately the consumer only gains an intangible experience on departure. Experiences felt by tourists can be classed into four 'realms of experience' which is shown in Fig 2.2. Realms of experience are the "underlying features of tourism experience have been theorised as four realms" (Jurowski, 2009, p. 2).

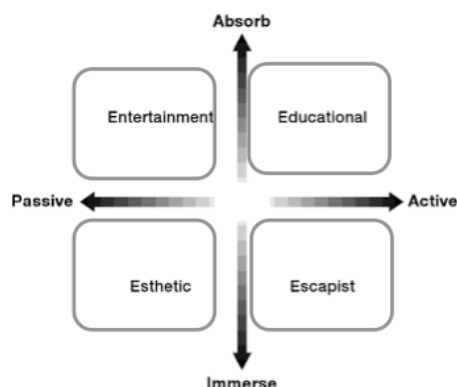


Figure 2: Four Realms of Experience (Pine & Gilmore, 2011).

Bunratty Castle and Folk Park was chosen as the Heritage attraction under investigation as the product offering provides all off the realms of experience prior, during and

post experience For example, the educational element can be obtained through research conducted using web 2.0 elements such as social media, blogs and forums.

2.2.2. Urban Attractions

One of the earliest forms of tourism was "urban tourism.... when the European aristocrats started to travel to towns and cities...since the 1980's there was a major shift from this towards coastal, rural and mountainous destinations" (Colantonio & Potter, 2006). Over the past decade, increased globalisation is generating significant interest in tourists wanting to visit urban destinations therefore; urban tourism is a re-emerging sector of tourism. Forming a definition of this sector of tourism can be complex, yet a simple definition has been formed, "attractions hosted in urban areas" (Hall & Page, 2006, p. 130). The Guinness Storehouse is based in a large city and the story delivered to customers is based on activities in the city, hence Guinness Storehouse is an urban attraction.

2.2.3 Natural Attractions

Natural tourism is any type of tourism that relies on experiences directly related to natural attractions. Acquiring additional funds to protect and enhance natural attractions is always a concern in managing sustainable tourism however many natural based tourism attractions are now charging for entry (Reynisdottir, Song, Agrusa, 2008). In a study of motivations for visiting Ireland, Tourism Ireland found that three of the top rated motivations were for the unspoilt environment. The Cliffs of Moher was chosen as the natural attraction under review and has the third highest visitor numbers in 2012, for that reason the research will establish whether their social media efforts are a consequence for the significant visitor numbers.

2.3. Tourism operator's use of social media as a marketing tool

There are a number of different reasons why tourism operators have opted to use social media as a marketing tool. Inbound visitor numbers to Ireland decreased by 12% in 2009 and then a further 11% in 2010 as a result of the global economic crises (overall performance in 2009, Failteireland.com). Once the Irish tourism industry began to see an incline of inbound tourists in 2011, which presented an increase of 9% in just the first quarter of the year, the next step for tourism operators was to adapt new strategies to increase visitor numbers and save costs. One of their cost saving strategies was adaption of online social profiles as a new marketing tool "social networking systems can be used to reduce costs and inefficiencies" (Hartley, 2010, P. 59). This form of online marketing is driven by user-generated content (hereafter referred to as UGC) therefore tourism operators need to monitor the effects of the UGC as it is "a mixture of fact and opinion, impression and sentiment ... experiences, even rumours" (Blackshaw and Nazzaro, 2004 P.4). Tourism operators cannot control the contents posted however

ensuring the facts are legitimate and pre-conceived impressions are positive helps, mitigate the negative impacts of the content shared. Parra-Lopez et al (2011) identified three stages of the holiday purchasing process: Pre-consumption, consumption, post-consumption (Parra-Lopez et al, 2011). All stages can be penetrated by social media therefore tourism operators have the ability to influence the decision to visit their visitor attraction, the experience at the visitor attraction and the feedback and review through a UGC page.

2.4. Importance of Social Media for Tourism Industry Operators

The United Nations World Tourism Organisation (UNWTO) 2012 conference discussed the importance of social media in the future of the tourism industry and develop a strategy focusing on how social media can help to mitigate the negative effects of a crisis and influence safe practices by tourists. The Irish Destination Marketing Organisation (DMO) Tourism Ireland provide downloadable content for tourism operators to develop their social media content and the National Tourism Development Authority (Fáilte Ireland) holds information seminars for industry operators to learn about online marketing and the use and benefits of social media. This identifies that national tourism industries are embracing the social media phenomenon because they understand the benefits. Fig 2.3 shows the effort being made by Fáilte Ireland to drive tourism business to social media by placing hyperlinks to the social networking websites on the toolbar. "A hyperlink is a link from one web page or file to another" (Moffet, 2012). These hyperlinks help drive tourism operators to liaise via social networking.



Figure 3: Toolbar of social networking hyperlinks.

Businesses in "networked markets have figured out that they get far better information and support from one another than from vendors" (Locke et al, 1999). According to tourist trends, 70% of tourists use the internet for travel planning. One imperative factor is linking the relationship between the tourist and the social media page which in most cases is the search engine. "Search engines have become a powerful interface that serves as the 'gateway' to travel-related information" (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010, p. 179); however, the amount of exposure a tourist gets to social media websites as opposed to other tourism websites when using a search engine, is still undefined (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010, pp. 179-180).

Tourism is concentrated of facts, figures and statistics therefore, "it is critical to understand changes in technology and consumer behaviour that impact the distribution and accessibility of travel-related information" (Xiang and

Gretzel, 2010, p 179). Before visitor attractions begin or continue their social media live profile, it is recognised by many academics (Xiang & Gretzel, 2010; Milano et al, 2011; Pan & Crofts, 2011) that the purpose of having an online profile in social networking is the means to survive and be successful in the current market and behaviour that impacts consumer choice must be understood. There is an intricate relationship between social media as an information hub and the person who avails of this information; however, "understanding this complex and dynamic relationship is important for harnessing the power of social networks for marketing" (Pan and Crofts 2011, p. 4).

2.5. Challenges of Social Media

Understanding social media is one of the biggest challenges facing businesses that utilise this online domain. Users of the online platforms need to understand and effectively employ social networking in order to gain marketing and communication benefits with their consumers. Having an inactive page that is still live on social media networks can have negative effects merely by reputation or discernment of customers who search for and view the profile page that are lacklustre, uninteresting and monotonous. Milano et al. (2011) discussed how "lack of resources, poor technical competence and sluggish management are usually claimed to explain the modest adoption of any type of information technology by tourism enterprises" (Milano et al. 2011, p. 10). It takes at least 25% to 50% of a full time employees time to effectively run and manage a social media campaign (Turner, 2012). If tourism operators do not invest sufficient time or effort in social media, no benefits can be obtained and consequently will lack the necessary participation that is required to succeed in today's travelling market.

Many marketers are used to the traditional method of marketing however integration with social media as a marketing tool is critical. Companies may feel the two are very different, yet "in the customer's eyes they are both part of the ... corporate image" (Kaplan and Haelein, 2010, p. 65). Traditional marketers might find social media as a difficult and very diverse method of marketing and this can ultimately pose a massive challenge as both forms of marketing are not integrated. There were problems identified regarding marketers adjusting to internet changes when the World Wide Web increased in 1990s but a technology-driven shift is again occurring now with the broad adoption of Web 2.0 technologies by both consumers and organisations (Shao, Rodriguez and Gretzel, 2010, p. 87).

2.6. Future Trends

"Social media is an online environment that changes at a very quick pace. What might be up-to-date today could have disappeared from the virtual landscape tomorrow" (Kaplan and Haelein, 2010, p. 65). Nearly two and a half billion people in the world have access to the internet either through a computer or mobile device. Approximately 63% of the

world's internet users accessed social networking sites in 2012. The introduction of numerous Information Communication Technologies (ICT's) such as smartphones, tablets, laptops, music devices, and e-readers have resulted in the rapid growth of social media and consumer generated content.

Search engine optimisation (hereafter referred to as SEO) is a current trend that helps "improve visibility of a website in search engines without paying for the results" (Terrelongé, 2011, p. 10). The relationship between social media and search engines seems to be one of complexity; however, through the understanding of search engines algorithms, visitor attraction operators can improve the rankings of social networking pages on the search engines. Algorithms tend to be complex but due to the nature of the construction, social media pages are constantly being updated, include a number of hyperlinks, have a large volume of visitors and in some cases are the best match to the keyword questioned (Xiang and Gretzel, 2010). "Online tourism marketers ... face fierce competition from social media because the search process can lead millions of consumers to highly-relevant social media content" (Blackshaw and Nazzaro, 2006 as cited by Tuominen, 2011, p. 6). Sigala, Evangelou and Gretzel (2010) have analysed the revolutionising of social media over the last number of years and have identified trends that they feel will emerge over the next five years; however, will have a short life span in the ever changing social networking scene. Geo-location, (also referred to as location-based networks) which is the first example, allows a user's current location to be identified. Geo-location then "allows companies to show products or services that are available in particular areas" (Maya, 2012, p. 115). Wireless energy devices are gadgets that can transfer electrical energy from power sources without a conductor. Examples of such devices are wireless battery tools that can be used for mobile devices therefore a tourist will always have additional battery should they want to access the internet. Lastly, augmented reality which is "taking digital or computer-generated information ... and overlaying them in a real time environment" (Kipper & Rampolla, 2013, p. 1), which can be used for tourism purposes such as online maps showing real life locations, with an overlay of computer-generated information on the screen.

The global tourism industry, and subsequently the Irish tourism industry social media campaign are currently in action to lead tourism operators to the new world of marketing. The literature review has revealed social networking is growing at a remarkable rate and consequently tourism operators will need to adapt to succeed. The rapid evolution of information communication technologies is promoting tourists to review or submit UGC throughout all stages of their travel process. According to Moore's law, computer power doubles every two years, therefore the advances of social networking theoretically will follow this prediction. Many authors are trying to re-iterate the importance of tourism operator's essential shift to more social network usage. It is also crucial to progress the way tourists and technology are progressing, as traditional marketing efforts will no longer be adequate to attract visitor

numbers necessary to allow the business to be more operationally sound. There are gaps in the literature regarding the benefits, pitfalls and the predictions for the future. Visitor attractions use of social networking is one such gap in the literature. Although there has been numerous diagnostics of what strategies visitor attractions should achieve, there is minimal literature support for attraction providers aiming to develop their social media profiles. Subsequent to the gaps in the literature pinpointed in this paper, the researcher will conduct primary research to obtain new data and findings from the visitor attractions tourist group.

3. Methodology

3.1. Introduction

In order to complete an extensive understanding of the research topic, this paper outlines the methods of research chosen to obtain results using the most suitable approach to the research. Marshall et al (2002) and McDaniel (1995) state that there are three basic methodologies available to researchers, these are observation, experimentation and survey (Marshall et al, 2002; McDaniel, 1995). All three methods were adopted by the researcher of this project. Research conducted was divided into two main sources – primary and secondary data (See figure 3.0). Secondary research was obtained from books, E-journals, websites and newspaper articles. Primary research was conducted using analytical tools such as questionnaires, interviews and social media observation.

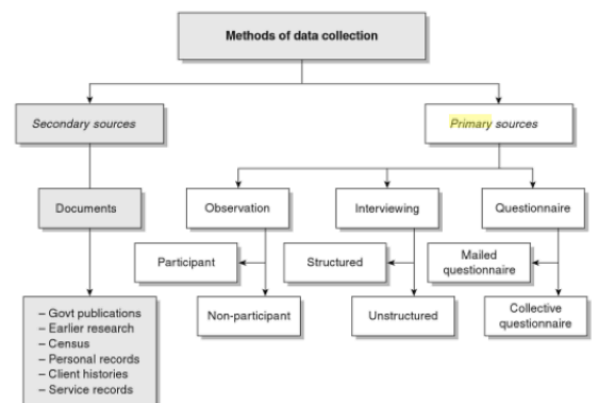


Figure 4: Methods of Data Collection (Kumar, 2011).

3.2. Secondary Research

Secondary research consists of an analysis of data that has already been produced and can be contemporary or historical, qualitative or quantitative. It can consist of books, articles, journals, diaries or any other publishing's. The researcher used this data to extract useful and relevant information already established relating to the research topic to help ascertain gaps in the published literature. The researcher conducted a literature review in paper one which distinguished areas of research that will assist the research paper. The results of

secondary research help to establish specific matters to obtain through the primary research. For advantages and disadvantages of secondary research please see appendix five.

There are many benefits to secondary data such as access to historical data, modern and contemporary conclusions from previous research. One essential benefit of secondary research is to examine the evolution of Web 1.0 to Web 2.0. The analysis will be used to examine trends over time (Finn, Elliott-White, Walton, 2000). It (secondary research) "can be a vital or incidental point of comparison" (Veal, 2006).

One of the most crucial dis-advantages of secondary research is that "they (data) have been collected for a particular purpose" (Finn, Elliott-White, Walton, 2000). Conclusions are based on the original topic therefore may not be relevant to the research in review. A further problem when conducting secondary analysis is the reference periods. As social media is a relatively new topic, much of the literature published is quite modern however, as computer power is doubling every two years, and technology advancing at a fast pace, what might seem new information today can be inaccurate tomorrow. The researcher aims to overcome this issue by using the newest literature available.

3.3. *Primary Research*

Primary research involves the collection of data that has not already been identified and are "sources that provide primary data such as interviews, observations and questionnaires" (Kumar, 2011, p. 393). The purpose of carrying out primary research is to gather specific and up to date results from the industry using both qualitative and quantitative methods. The information retrieved is specific to the topic under investigation and it allows for the researcher to identify any outstanding questions relating to the topic. The questions and topics used for the primary research were obtained following the discovery of gaps through secondary research detailed in the literature review.

3.4. *Qualitative Research vs. Quantitative data*

Qualitative data is expressed in the form of words as opposed to numbers. This form of research can be extremely varied, can welcome unknown questions in a questionnaire or interview and can provide vivid descriptions of a topic. The researcher's interview technique was adapted specifically to allow for qualitative data. There is an overlap between qualitative and quantitative data collection with the difference being in the way the information is generated. Quantitative data is the collection of numerical data. This data can be difficult to obtain through a one-on-one interview therefore the questions used in the online questionnaire and the social media monitoring will be the basis of the quantitative research. The results of the research paper will converge using the quantitative results from the questionnaires and the social media observation, and the qualitative results derived from the interviews.

3.5. *Sampling*

Sampling is creating a subset of people from a group. In relation to an interview or questionnaire it relates to the decision as to which publics you will question (Flick, 2009). There are a number of samples that would have been suitable for the questionnaires for example local residents, students, primary schools; however, the researcher chose to contact previous domestic and international visitors to any of the three attractions. This tactical choice was to guarantee that the respondents were all linked to the visitor attractions social networking profiles. Access was achieved by emailing a link for the online questionnaire to the individual respondents traced through the visitor attractions social media pages.

3.6. *Interview*

The researcher has carried out three interviews for the purpose of the research paper. The interview method assumed was semi-structured interviews. Interviews were requested with the employees who update the respective visitor attraction social networking profiles. The three interviewees were all asked the same questions in order to keep the results consistent. The interview was broken down into two parts; part one was related to their specific visitor attraction and part two was focusing on the individual being an industry operator. The researcher has been requested to forward the interview questions ahead of the interview in order for interviewees to prepare their responses. For transcripts of interviews, please see appendices one, two and three.

3.6.1 *Semi-structured interview*

The researcher chose semi-structured questions as they "combine the flexibility of the unstructured, open ended interview questions with the directionality and agenda of the survey instrument..." (Schensul et al, 1999, p. 174). "Interviews of this nature will have specified questions but will allow more probing to seek clarification and elaboration" (Finn et al, 2000, p. 73). The general nature of interviews is to try extracting as much information as possible however aiming to not deter the interviewee with difficult questions causing them to be resilient.

The adapted method of semi-structured interviews poses a number of benefits directly related to the research paper, for example, they allow for open-ended, conversational, two-way communication between the interviewer and interviewee. In relation to this research paper, the interviewer has no access to any specific information regarding a social media strategy before conducting the interview; therefore, the semi-structured questions allows for the interviewer to develop new questions and expand on existing questions throughout the interview.

Although this method of interview was selected by the researcher because it was the most appropriate method, like other interview methods it does present dis-advantages. Firstly, the interviewer may fail to take vital information and

may not probe for more details on a topic. There is the risk of the interviewee's response to some questions being quite broad or insensitive question may be asked incidentally. In order to overcome the issues, the researcher sent the questions to the interviewees prior to the scheduled meeting time allowing interviewee's scope to give information further to that asked.

3.7 Questionnaire

Although a very useful method of primary research, questionnaires pose a number of disadvantages. One publishing argued that quantitative research is an artificial creation by the researcher and the responses can lack validity as the information is limited without explanation. There is no way for the researcher to know how much thought has been put into the results and as the respondent may not be thinking in context while completing the questionnaire and results can be less accurate. Through the online source used, the researcher has no way of knowing whether potential respondents who do not complete the survey have even followed the link to the questionnaire before deciding not to respond.

Conducting questionnaires online offers greater anonymity to the respondents. Although the results will identify the profile of the customer, following the analysis, the researcher will be able to distinguish the customer's perception of the visitor attractions social media usage. The researcher's approach of mailed questionnaires is the most cost effective form of questionnaire. Due to the respondents being contacted through social networking sites, this method of conducting questionnaires is most suited.

Questionnaires were developed using an online survey site and the link mailed out to over one hundred previous tourists of the three visitor attractions on the 1st February 2013. One questionnaire was used for all tourists to ensure the results were coherent. The researcher chose the method of mailed questionnaires to allow for analysis, which is "the most common approach" (Kumar, 2011, p. 147), in order to be able to contact the friends and followers of the visitor attractions through their social media profile pages. Respondents will be targeted through Facebook, Twitter and Trip Advisor. For interview questions please see appendix six.

3.8 Pilot Testing

The researcher conducted pilot testing on the questionnaire with ten colleagues to identify if there were any issues that arose from conducting the questionnaire through an online source and to also gain feedback from the questions. Following the pilot testing, the researcher gained clarification that the questionnaire was easily accessible through the link provided and some minor modifications were made in relation to the phrasing of the questions. See appendix five for pilot questionnaire used.

3.9 Observation

Since the 1st November 2012 the researcher has been conducting social media observation which is the regular monitoring of a specific page to observe the changes and development of the profile. Each of the three visitor attractions under research were monitored through their Facebook, Twitter and Trip Advisor social networking profiles "Observation is a purposeful, systematic and selective way of watching and listening to an interaction or phenomenon as it takes place" (Kumar, 2011, p. 121). The method of observation undertaken by the researcher was non-participant observation which means the researcher is uninvolved in the process; for example, in the research paper context, the researcher can have no interference with the social media profiles. The purpose of choosing non participant observation will be to show that results are non-bias and are factual.

Non participant observation is an easy method of observation. It is beneficial that companies are not aware of the observation as this may impact the organic routine of updating and subsequent interference with the observation. Pitfalls to this approach are; the researcher chooses the events they deem significant and may interpret actions differently depending on their own opinions. The objective of social media observation is to note the organic activity and increase or decline of numbers, followers and fans. This will help to clarify whether the social networking activities already conducted by the visitor attractions are successful.

3.10 Reliability and Validity

Although efforts were made to ensure that the research methods were valid, there are a number of factors that limit the accuracy of the information received. None of the methods of data collection provide 100% accurate and reliable information. "The quality of the data gathered is dependent upon a number of other factors" (Kumar, 2011).

Some methods undertaken by the researcher to ensure the reliability of the research paper were;

- Respondents of the questionnaires participated voluntarily.
- Participants of the interview did so willingly and received the questions in advance to personally review the questions.
- The researcher conducted non-participant observation of the social networking profiles to eliminate any influence over results, allowing all results to be organic.

3.11 Limitations of Methodology

The main limitation of the research methodology is the distribution of questionnaires. The researcher chose to interact with previous tourists of the attractions that are linked to one or more of the attractions social networking profiles. The researcher then had to ensure that each of the three visitor attractions had equal numbers of respondents

for consistent results. Individual respondents are located following an interaction with one of the visitor attractions social media profiles and contact made could be considered to be unsolicited.

As the researcher mentioned in the previous paper, the reliability and validity of the literature review can be limited. As the industry changes and develops, the literature previously published can become outdated. Although efforts were made to use the most recent published literature, at the completion of this project, some of the literatures validity may be compromised as the information may be considered out-dated.

Despite having designed the main objectives for the research paper, when conducting the methodology there is always the possibility of side-tracking from the conceptual framework whilst aiming to ensure accurate and suitable responses are gathered.

Research for a dissertation should contain a mix of both primary and secondary data. Having researched a number of different methods to conduct the primary and secondary data, the researcher feels that the most appropriate methods of research were assumed. The methodology does contain limitations; however, all necessary steps have been taken to minimise the effect of any such limitations.

4. Data and Findings

4.1. Introduction

In this paper the researcher will combine all data and findings to conduct data analysis on both primary and secondary research. Analysis of data is “a process of evaluating data using analytical and logical reasoning to examine each component of the data provided” (businessdictionary.com). For the collection and analysis of this data Microsoft excel will be engaged as the researcher has previous experience using this program for data presentation.

4.2. Findings of secondary research

The researcher conducted a thorough investigation of the literature available relating to this research paper focusing on social media and visitor attractions. It was found that a large proportion of the research focuses mainly on the necessity of social media in the tourism industry yet the literature was lacking significant information regarding visitor attractions use of social media and tourism industry operator's initial stages of beginning their social media life cycle. The literature already published defines the topic of social media, the importance and the benefits. However, very few academics have conducted research on how to create social networking sites, what specific websites are relevant to different sectors of the industry and ultimately predictions for the future.

As this is a relatively new topic, the above mentioned sections can be difficult to study and will undoubtedly take time to be researched by academics; however, as the rate of

computer power doubles every two years according to Moore's law, action needs to be pursued instantaneously by academics and industry operators alike. This gap in the literature supports the researcher's objectives to distinguish what top visitor attractions are currently doing to keep up with the market.

4.3. Findings of primary data

4.3.1. Interviews

The researcher carried out three interviews with the personnel who are in charge of regulating and updating the social media pages of the three visitor attractions under analysis. The interviewees were Katherine Webster, the Director of the Cliffs of Moher, Lisa Fitzsimons, Marketing and Sales Manager at the Guinness Storehouse and John Horgan, Sales and Marketing of Bunratty castle. The researcher segmented the interviews into two parts. Part one are company focused questions and part two are industry operator questions. The purpose of categorising the questions was to obtain the relevant company information but then also gaining a personal insight from the industry operator. The most relevant analyses questions are outlined below, further analysis of remaining questions can be found in appendix nine. A full transcript of interviews can be found in appendices one, two and three. Interviews were conducted between the 19th January and the 11th February.

Part 1

1. What social networking sites does the company have a profile on?

All three visitor attractions have a social media profile on Facebook, Twitter and Trip Advisor. Over the course of this research paper, the researcher monitored the top 10 social networking websites as per ebizma.com each month. Ebizma.com derives its information from global traffic rankings online. Facebook and Twitter have been ranked places one and two respectively since the research began in October 2012 (Ebizma.com, 2012/2013). This shows that all three attractions have utilized the top social networking sites therefore granting access to the largest possible audience.

2. How often are the attractions social media profiles updated?

Although all attractions regularly update their profile, the response to the question when asked was unanimous among the three attractions. “Our online social platforms are updated, monitored and reviewed a few times a day” (Lisa Fitzsimons, Guinness Storehouse). Similarly, Katherine Webster of the Cliffs of Moher said “it is hard to know how long I actually spend checking the pages but approximately twenty minutes a day, seven days a week”. John Horgan of Bunratty Castle and Folk Park identified that they update their social media profiles three to five days per week. Depending on any company size it difficult to know exactly how long or how often updates should be made to maintain

engagement with their followers. Socialbakers.com is one of the biggest social media statistics portals in the world and they carried out social media monitoring for the purpose of identifying how many updates were being posted on the pages of some international and well know companies. Fig 5 shows the results over a three month period.

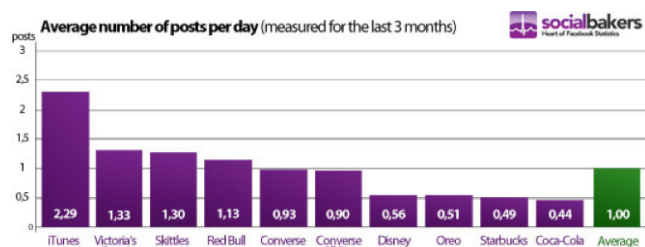


Figure 5: Average number of social media posts per day for a large company.

This establishes that the visitor attractions are updating their profiles less often than those of larger international companies however as the businesses are relatively smaller, they are not necessarily lacking in their efforts.

3. Do you use any social media management tools such as a dashboard?

As identified in the literature review, one of the biggest challenges industry operators find with social media is finding the time to update new content. The information posted should be interesting, engaging, and relevant. Further to this, the type of content depends on the social networking site used. Micro blogging is a brief digital conversation which may only consist of one hundred and forty characters and digital media which is a picture or video that requires more time and effort to upload on a page for example on YouTube. Lisa Fitzsimons of the Guinness Storehouse confirms that they do use a management tool which is Hootsuite.com. Katherine Webster of the Cliffs of Moher does not use any management tools because their team are not fully aware of which tool is best to utilise. Ms Webster revealed that she was contacted by Facebook to be informed of Facebook's 'page manager' which was only specific to Apple devices. The adoption of this page manager was declined by Ms Webster as personally, she finds you cannot sufficiently manage your social media profiles through Apple devices such as the iPhone or iPad, and prefers to use a PC in order to review all content and utilise all elements of the site for example "sharing" a post from a followers page to their own page.

4. Do you aim to focus the company's social media profile on your sector of the tourism industry i.e. Heritage/Urban/Natural Tourism?

The aim of this question was to see if any of the visitor attraction focused their strategy on their particular sector of the tourism industry. Ms Webster of the Cliffs of Moher stated that their initial strategy was to "just see what this (social networking) is all about, is it a way we can engage with

our customers" and they used this strategy to learn as they go. Although their strategy is not focused on natural tourism, they do aim to re-post photos of the Cliffs to show past and future tourists its natural beauty. Ms Fitzsimons of the Guinness Storehouse said that their social media objectives are "to engage with and build the online community through engaging content. This content is focused on the Guinness brand rather than Dublin", although Lisa mentioned that Dublin, which is an urban destination, is sometimes the theme of content that they use from time to time.

5. Does your attraction have a social media strategy? Has there been in the past / will there be in the future?

Both the Guinness Storehouse and Bunratty Castle have a social media strategy in place and mentioned that their strategy will continue to be developed in the future. Katherine Webster of the Cliffs of Moher admitted that their initial strategy was figuring out what social networking was about, what are the benefits and how could they use this domain. Moving forward Ms Webster stated that they understand that a strategy will need to be put in place as the whole concept is very time consuming therefore changes such as adding more staff to the process and training employees about their company guidelines will be a necessary step going forward.

5. Is the company connected through the management centre on trip advisor?

The Trip Advisor management centre is a tool for industry operators or managers to sign up as the operator of a particular business or place on the website and allows for editing the content of the company profile and replying to reviews left by visitors. The Guinness Storehouse has the most reviews on Trip Advisor out of the three attractions. Ms Fitzsimons has said that their visitor experience manager "replies to every single review on Trip Advisor both positive and negative". Katherine Webster of the Cliffs of Moher said that they were not connected until Trip Advisor contacted them and encouraged the company to sign up. John Horgan of Bunratty Castle was unfamiliar with the Trip Advisor management centre which would suggest that the company does not reply to positive and negative comments through Trip Advisor.

Part 2

7. Do you think there are any risks to industry operators not utilising social media?

"You have to fish where the fish are" (Lisa Fitzsimons). Ms Fitzsimons says that if you ignore social media then you are ignoring an incredibly influential and powerful communication channel as you can reach a large audience. Ms Webster of the Cliffs of Moher says that companies are wasting an opportunity by not being involved in social media. She mentioned that as their attraction is a natural attraction there is an opportunity for anyone to create and manage a social media profile of their attraction before the company

has a chance to do so. As they are a graphical location they are not copyright, therefore anyone can make up a similar social network page in place of them which will in time damage the brand.

8. Do you receive any support from Fáilte Ireland or Tourism Ireland in relation to your social media?

Ms Webster of the Cliffs of Moher and Mr Horgan of Bunratty Castle both have said that they receive useful training from Fáilte Ireland a few times a year focusing on their social media and online domains; however, Ms Fitzsimons from Guinness Storehouse said “We don’t receive training – I guess being part of a global multinational means all the training is provided in house”, however she did clarify that they do liaise often with both Fáilte Ireland and Tourism Ireland.

4.3.2. Questionnaires

Questionnaires were carried out online through the online survey software tool SurveyMonkey.com. Pilot surveys were first conducted on the 22nd January 2013 and the final survey was completed and forwarded to respondents on the 24th January. The research contacted one hundred friends or followers of the three visitor attractions under research. Fifty nine people were contacted through Facebook; Twenty Five people were contacted on Trip Advisor and the final sixteen people through Twitter. One of the visitor attractions also re-tweeted the researcher’s personal request through Twitter; this would have reached their one thousand followers. The researcher chose to conduct online questionnaires in order to identify the profile of the social networking community following the visitor attractions and to identify, as users of the same social media domains, what would attract them to a visitor attractions page.

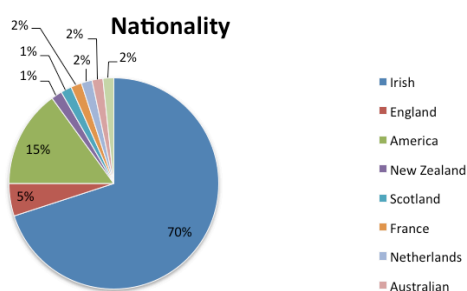


Figure 6: Nationality of Respondents.

The researcher’s first question was the nationality of each respondent. All sixty respondents chose to answer this question. Fig 6.0 shows that 70% of all respondents were Irish. All other respondents are from America, England, New Zealand, Scotland, France, Netherlands, Australia and Africa.

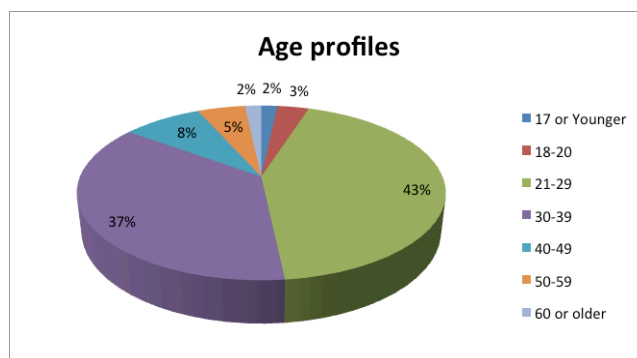


Figure 7: Age profile of respondents.

Gathering an age profile of respondents both gives a brief overview of the profile of tourists visiting Irish visitor attractions but also gives the reader a customary age profile of the users of social media pages. In figure 4.2, 80% of all respondents are between the ages of twenty one and thirty nine which is a significant volume of respondents. As the researcher mentioned in the literature review, the biggest users and target of any online domains are generation Y. This generation grew up with the development of internet and are undoubtedly at the age of understanding as generation Y are said to be the best educated generation. The lowest scoring ages were the ‘17 and under’, and ‘60 or Older’.

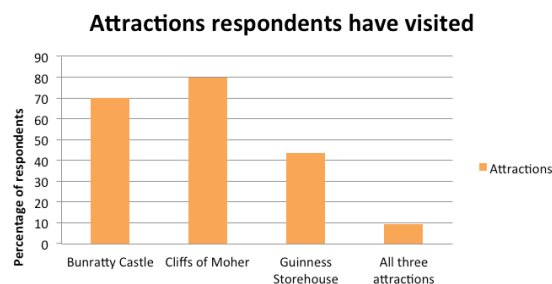


Figure 8: Visitor attractions the respondents visited.

The researcher developed just one questionnaire for all respondents as it was felt that applying different questionnaires to each tourist would create imbalanced results. The majority of respondents, 80% in total visited the Cliffs of Moher. Following that result a total of 70% of respondents also visited Bunratty Castle which is located in the same county. 43% of respondents visited the Guinness Storehouse and just a total of 9% said they had visited all three attractions.

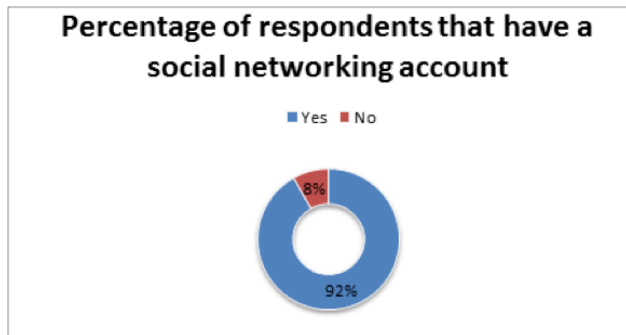


Figure 9: Percentage of respondents that have a social networking account

The researcher asked respondents whether they had an account on any social media page. The majority of the sample, 92% said they did have a social media profile and just 8% said they did not. The researcher then asked all respondents with a social networking account to name or list the account(s) in which they use. Of the 92% of respondents,

- 95% use Facebook
- 42% use Twitter
- 29% use Trip Advisor
- 25% use YouTube
- 14% use Instagram
- 11% use LinkedIn

Other social networking sites used by less than 10% of respondents are; Bebo, Geni, Google+, Pinterest, Eumom, Boards, Pigsback, Busuu, Xooit and Dailymotion.

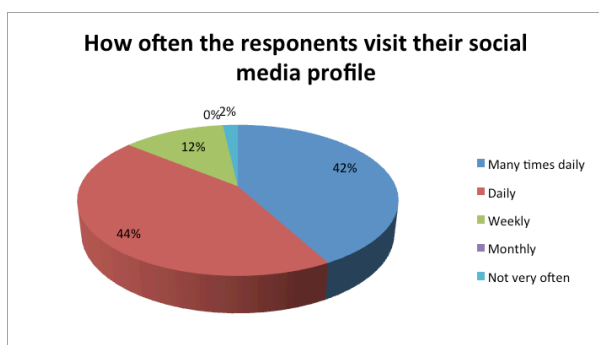


Figure 10: Amount of time respondents visit their social media profile.

In the researcher's opinion, one of the biggest reasons why it is recommended for companies to use interesting content and to update regularly is due to the regular viewings by each user. The researcher asked respondents how often they visit their social media profile to get an idea of how often this sample of tourists are exposed to viewing the content online. 86% of the sample view their social media profiles daily. 42% of the total sample view their social media many times daily. The response to this question shows that just 12% of people may check their profile weekly and just 2% do not check their profiles very often.

Do you use the internet to choose what activities to do when on vacation?

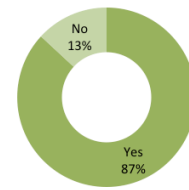


Figure 11: Percentage of respondents who use the internet to choose vacation activities.

The researcher asked respondents if they used the internet to choose what activities to do when on vacation. A staggering 87% of respondents said that they do use the internet to make plans for their vacation. These results reflect findings from the literature review literature that 70% of tourists use the internet for travel planning. The remaining 13% of respondents stated that they do not use the internet for travel planning.

Would you view a visitor attractions social media profile page before visiting the attraction



Figure 12: Percentage of respondents who view an attractions social media page before travelling to the destination.

Following on from the previous question, the research aimed for a more specific approach to identify the samples trend. When asked would they view a visitor attractions social media page before deciding to visit the attraction, 68% of respondents said they would occasionally view their social networking pages, 20% said they would always view the attraction social networking page and 12% said they would never view their pages.

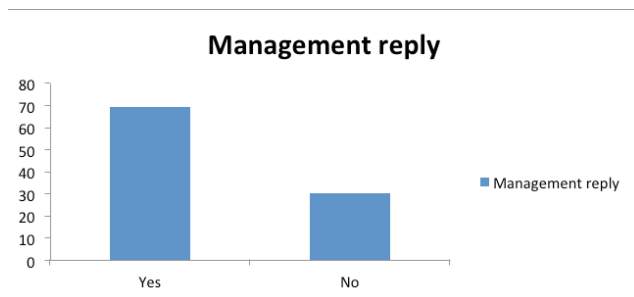


Figure 13: Percentage of respondents who would choose a visitor attraction over another if there was a management reply to reviews.

Respondents were asked whether seeing a management reply to comments on review sites such as Trip Advisor. Com would encourage them to use choose to visit the visitor attraction. 69.5% said that it would encourage them to choose that attraction and 30.5% said that would not.

4.3.3. Social Media Monitoring

Social media monitoring (hereafter referred to as SMM) is a systematic analysis of social media inputs. The researcher conducted SMM over a fourteen week period beginning on the 1st November 2012. SMM can be adapted using qualitative and quantitative approaches. For this research paper a quantitative method was adapted for the systematic analysis. This is very beneficial to a company as they will be able to see clearly, in real time, whether their campaign is working and viewers are increasing. For any company reviewing conversations in real-time is “a qualitative exercise that can’t always be outsourced” (Sweeney & Craig, 2011, p. 167).

	November	December	January	February	Total
Guinness Storehouse	25071	27094	28908	29421	4350
Bunratty Castle and Folk Park	1171	1247	1337	1363	192
Cliffs of Moher	14657	15316	16496	16820	2163

Figure 14: Incline of Facebook likes over a four month period.

Facebook is the top social networking website worldwide in member numbers. Figure 14.0 shows the number of members who ‘liked’ the visitor attractions social media pages per month. All three attractions display an increase in numbers; however, the Guinness Storehouse results show that their numbers have increased a staggering twenty two times more than Bunratty Castle and Folk Park’s results. As identified during the interview stage, Guinness Storehouse has a social media strategy in place therefore great efforts are placed in creating their social networking community. Every time a person ‘likes’ a company’s page they are then exposed to any updates made by the company which then permits free marketing.

	November	December	January	February	Total
Guinness Storehouse	1689	1698	1963	2001	312
Bunratty Castle and Folk Park	1925	1982	2045	2061	136
Cliffs of Moher	858	888	985	1008	150

Figure 15: Incline of Twitter followers over a four month period.

Figure 15.0: Shows the incline of twitter follow from November 2012 to February 2013. As Twitter is a form of micro-blogging it is crucial for the content uploaded to be interesting and engaging in order to gain and retain followers. This shows that although the three attractions current approach is effective however improvements can be made.

	November	December	January	February	Total
Guinness Storehouse	2827	2924	3054	3085	258
Bunratty Castle and Folk Park	601	618	630	636	35
Cliffs of Moher	792	819	845	855	63

Figure 16: Trip Advisor traveller review numbers.

The most influential reason tourists may select what activity to choose on vacation is travel review websites. 90% of people trust peer recommendations; therefore review websites such as Trip Advisor have a powerful effect of the consumer’s decision. Content posted on such websites are consumer generated therefore companies have no control over the comments. Encouraging tourists to review your visitor attraction is one way to prompt a positive presence on Trip Advisor. All three attractions mentioned in the interviews that they urge departing guests to leave a review on Trip Advisor and have the logo on their company website. The Guinness Storehouse includes a call to action to leave a review on Trip Advisor on the confirmation email sent to tourists who book online. The result of including the call to action is reflected in the numbers of traveller review left on Tripadvisor.com in figure 16.0 as the Guinness Store house has over seven times that of Bunratty Castle and Folk Park, and four times as many as the Cliffs of Moher.

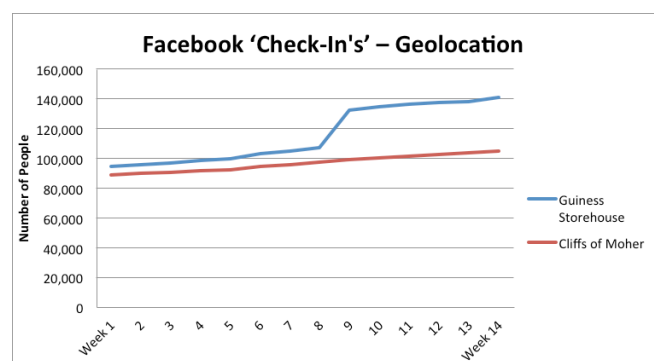


Figure 17: Facebook ‘check-in’ Numbers.

Location-based sharing is the process of digitally posting your current location onto your social media profile, otherwise known to Facebook users as 'checking in'. Once a user has checked into a location, this information is posted on the update feeds of their friends and followers; therefore it may generate interest among others. Figure 17.0 displays the incline of people sharing their location in the Guinness Storehouse and the Cliffs of Moher. There is a sharp increase during week eight and week nine on the Guinness Storehouse graph which was over the Christmas and New Year period. Location-Based services were unavailable for Bunratty Castle and Folk Park. Full results can be found in appendix seven.

4.4. *Limitations to primary research*

The researcher aimed to receive one hundred or more responses to the questionnaire; however, only sixty respondents replied. As the questionnaire was conducted through an online source there was no way of knowing which tourists responded therefore the researcher could not send a reminder to all.

Although the researcher was able to conduct the interviews with each attraction, some responses to the questions were either too basic or invalid in order to compare the responses to each other.

Following the presentation of data, the researcher has highlighted that the benefits of social media are not fully understood by the visitor attraction operators, as mentioned initially in the literature review. Although the three attractions under review have company profiles on a number of social media sites, it does not seem to be fully utilised by some of the attractions. Further to the review of questionnaires, the reader is shown that the majority of tourists contacted for the purpose of the research paper are using social networking for travel planning. It also resulted in the conclusion that tourists are online often enough for new information to reach a large segment of the tourists.

5. Conclusion and recommendations

5.1.1. *Importance of visitor attraction operators utilising social media*

The first objective of the research paper was to understand why it is important that visitor attractions employ social media in their strategic marketing plan. As Katherine Webster from the Cliffs of Moher mentioned, regardless of whether the attraction created a profile on social networking profiles, both positive and negative consumer generated content will continue to be posted online therefore it is in the attractions best interest to monitor, reply and update any content possible. Lisa Fitzsimmons said that 'you have to fish where the fish are' which suggests that there are opportunities to attract consumers through these online platforms. John Horgan of Bunratty Castle expressed that their particular target markets use social media. In 2012, there

were over 1.43 billion users of social networks which is a 19% increase in the previous year (www.emarketer.com). Each market segment is becoming more accustomed to using the internet for travel planning, prompting visitor attractions and other tourism operators to move to where the target market is moving.

5.1.2. *Changes in the online marketing environment and requirements of tourism operators*

Traditionally when internet became part of the travel planning process, it was to search vacations through online travel agents. Marketer's strategies were to push consumers to book through an online site using online recommendations from the travel agent website. Review websites then emerged and began dominating the online tourism domain, particularly penetrating the budget consumer; they offered more attractive packages while providing the tourist with real traveller reviews. Although review sites are still governing the planning process, social media sites are becoming more attractive to the market. Through the travel planning process used by tourists online, companies are regaining control over the tourist decisions by actively pursuing social networking as a method for attracting consumers. As per the results of social media monitoring, the reader can see that the Guinness Storehouse is certainly the participant which has achieved the highest growth over the fourteen weeks. The Guinness Storehouse is the attraction with the highest visitor numbers in Ireland in 2012 (Fáilteireland.com). Although the researcher cannot prove that this is directly related, an assumption was rendered that due to the Guinness Storehouse developing a social networking strategy and increasing their online community, they increase their visitor numbers.

5.1.3. *Challenges resulting from the use of social media*

As the topic of social media in tourism has only fully emerged in the last decade, it is difficult to ascertain if businesses are reluctant to share bad experiences; however one significant challenge the researcher has identified is the effects of UGC. Web 2.0 is consistent of many forms of user generated content that can contain both positive and negative content. Businesses cannot control negative comments posted by tourists online and this in turn can damage the reputation or brand. The Cliffs of Moher is just one of many visitor attractions who faced online impersonation. Attractions that are not copyright and are based on a location or natural landscape face a threat of imitation sites linking with consumers. Another challenge that the researcher has encountered is the marginal use of social media. Tourism operators creating social media profiles and neglecting to update or post interesting content can also damage the brand as consumer's perception of the visitor attraction may be depleted. If the visitor attractions do not update their content then they will fail to attract an online community which will not provide any benefit to the company.

5.1.4. *Differentiating between re-active or pro-active use of social networking*

Social networking is being utilised by many tourism industry operators, yet some of which do not know how to use this platform. Pro-active use of social media is when a business utilises the social media websites that benefit their company, updating the content is consistent, adaptations to their approach are applied when necessary and constant research is conducted by the management. Being pro-active through this marketing tool is the means of keeping on top of the market trends online. When a tourism business is being re-active, they are nominally updating their social media profiles and no efforts are being made to attract more friends.

In relation to the visitor attractions used for this research project, the research has identified that Bunratty Castle is being re-active to social media. Although their profile pages are live on a number of social networking sites, minimal updates are being made. Bunratty Castle and Folk Park is also represented through Shannon Heritage social media; however, once tourists search Bunratty Castle they will be directed to the least active pages. John Horgan mentioned in the interview that Shannon Heritage does receive a higher visitor reach, yet visitors may not be aware that there is a second page relating to the visitor attraction.

5.2. *Recommendations*

The researcher established a number of future trends in relation to social media in the literature review, many of which directly relate to the tourism industry. Following the interviews with the three visitor attraction employees, there was a unanimous plan forward which corresponds with the identification made in the literature review. The future trends for visitor attractions are:

- To link with newer social media websites such as Google+ and Pinterest. All three interviewees mentioned that their first step will be to navigate which social media sites are best to link with. Before creating new profile they will explore and learn the benefits and pitfalls of new social media sites.
- Location based services (geo-location) is a trend already available and used by many tourism businesses. Future movement for visitor attractions identified following the interviews are, offering Wi-Fi facilities to customers, or similarly extending the Wi-Fi to all areas occupied by visitors to promote 'checking-in' to the location or uploading videos.
- Better integration with their company website. Visitor attractions have the opportunity to influence consumers planning process by integrating their social media with the company website. This can be particularly beneficial for posting regular and new updates that may be more difficult or time consume to add to the company homepage.
- As the researcher identified in the introduction, review sites are consisted of consumer generated content therefore companies have minimal influence over the content posted. Linking with the management centre on Trip Advisor allows a company to post professional photos add descriptive

literature and respond to both positive and negative comments.

Having completed a study on the future of social media, the following recommendations have been established:

- Visitor attractions should develop a thorough social media strategy. Feedback and results can be achieved and measured after the management identify what it is they want to gain from the online marketing tool. A social media strategy will result in better time management for employees and ensures that new information reaches the market segments.
 - Setting a daily time schedule for focusing on social media can be difficult for many marketers as existing tasks can be heavy and it can be hard to see the return on investment. Fitting this into the existing workload can result in less efforts being conducted and social media being the last task conducted by the employee. The literature review identified that for a small company, a full time employee should spend approximately 25% of their time working on social media. Setting a time frame every day ensures that time is utilised correctly on social media.
 - Supporting the time management can be achieved by using a management tool such as a dashboard. Updating and monitoring all the social media profile pages can be more efficient once a dashboard is used.
 - Research needs to be constant to ensure that the visitor attractions are availing of all available tools offered by the social media website. Social media can change on a daily basis therefore linking with tools such as the management centre on Trip Advisor will provide direct contact from social media websites about changes and new tools available.
- It is clear from paper five that the aims and objectives set out for this research paper in paper one have been achieved. The researcher recognises that some of the gaps in the literature identified following the literature review are due to the topic being quite new in the tourism industry. Further research is needed to develop guidelines for how social media should be adapted and actions that can be assumed to best manage negative content. The researcher assumed an approach of looking at three sectors of the tourism industry to identify if a specific approach to content posted on the social media websites should be employed by each sector. Following no identification through the literature review, the question was passed to the interviews. Responses from the interviews stated their approach is not specifically focused on their sector of the tourism industry therefore the researcher concludes that currently, it is not necessary that a visitor attraction should emphasise their sector of the tourism industry. Further research is recommended to understand the benefits and pitfalls of adapting this specific approach.

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